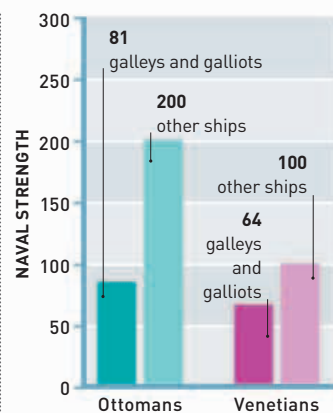




This scene from a fresco in Chehel Stun Palace in Isfahan, Iran, depicts Safavid Emperor Shah Ismail I in battle against Uzbek warriors.

but it also initiated the route used throughout the “Age of Sail” (see pp.172–73).

The ongoing **Ottoman naval threat** to Christendom was underlined by the Venetian–Ottoman War of 1499–1503. Both sides enjoyed profitable trade links. But Venetian sea-power represented an obstacle to Ottoman designs in the **eastern Mediterranean**. The Venetian defeat at the **Battle of Zonchio** in August 1499 made Ottoman naval power strikingly clear.



Zonchio ship numbers

The disparity in numbers between the Ottoman and Venetian fleets was compounded by the refusal of some Venetian commanders to fight at all.

A further round in the **Franco–Spanish struggle** for mastery of Italy was launched in 1499, when Louis XII of France (1462–1515) seized Milan. He then allied with Ferdinand of Aragon (1452–1516), agreeing to divide Naples between them. With Naples secured, Louis and Ferdinand fell out. Twice defeated by his former ally, **Louis reluctantly made peace** in 1504.

The burst of **European exploration** sparked by Columbus continued in 1500 when a **Spanish expedition** under Vicente Pinzón and a **Portuguese enterprise** under Pedro Alvares Cabral bound for India made the coast of **Brazil**. Cabral's sighting of this new land would prove important in establishing Portuguese claims to Brazil. Of greater significance was the growing realization that this was indeed a **New World**.

THE YEAR 1501 IS CONSIDERED the date the **Safavid Empire** was **founded**. With the Ottoman Empire to the west and the Mughal Empire to the east, it formed one of a bloc of sophisticated, centralized, **highly cultured Muslim empires** that dominated West Asia in the 16th and 17th centuries. It began in a burst of conquest launched by **Shah Ismail I**, whose troops surged westward across Persia, putting an end to the political vacuum and infighting that had followed the death of Timur (see 1386–90) in 1405. Proclaiming himself Shah of Persia, Ismail I was a Shi'ite Muslim and vigorously promoted his faith as the official state religion. Checked

Safavid Empire

From modest beginnings on the Caspian Sea, by 1501 the Safavid Empire extended to occupy a swath of Western Asia.



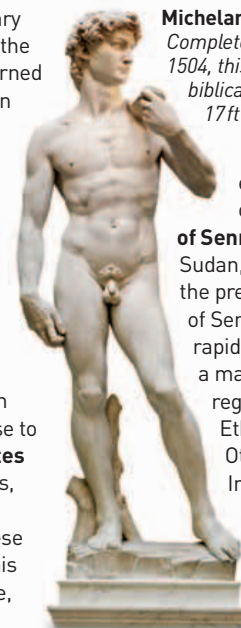
to the west by the military might of the Ottomans, the Safavids increasingly turned their focus to the east. In the process the Safavid capital was moved eastward, finally ending at Isfahan.

The introduction of African slaves by European settlers to the New World began in 1502, hardly 10 years after Columbus's first Atlantic crossing. In part, this was a response to the **alarming death rates** of the native populations, who had been similarly enslaved. The Portuguese rapidly followed suit. This initial phase of the trade, known as the **First Atlantic system**, lasted until around 1580.

The **spread of Islam** in East Africa was reinforced by the

Michelangelo's David

Completed by Michelangelo in 1504, this giant marble statue of biblical hero David stands at 17ft (5.2m) tall.



establishment in 1504 of the **Funj Sultanate of Sennar** in the north of Sudan, at the expense of the previous Christian rulers of Sennar. The sultanate rapidly established itself as a major power in the region, threatening both Ethiopia and the Ottomans in Egypt. In Europe, the **role of Florence** in the early years of the High Renaissance (see pp.204–205) was highlighted by **two remarkable**

works: Michelangelo's statue of *David*, which he completed in 1504; and Leonardo's painting *Mona Lisa*, completed sometime around 1505–07.

“...ANYONE WHO HAS SEEN MICHELANGELO'S DAVID HAS NO NEED TO SEE ANYTHING ELSE BY ANY OTHER SCULPTOR...”

Giorgio Vasari, Italian author, from *Lives of the Artists*, 1568

April 22, 1500 Portuguese explorer Pedro Alvares Cabral sights Brazil

April 1500 French defeat forces of Ludovico Sforza, Duke of Milan, at Novara, Milan

c. 1500 First Inuit settlement of Arctic

1500 Vicente Yañez Pinzón discovers mouth of Amazon River

1501 Accession of Shah Ismail I establishes Safavid dynasty, Persia

1502 Introduction of African slaves to Caribbean by Spanish

1502 Safavid ruler Shah Ismail I executes Sunni dissenters

1502 Donato Bramante, one of the greatest architects of the Renaissance, completes Tempietto (the “Little Chapel”), Rome

November 1, 1503 Giuliano de' Medici becomes Pope Julius II, beginning a period of remarkable artistic patronage in Rome

1503 Spanish army routs French forces at Cerignola, Italy

1504 Michelangelo completes statue of David

1504 Muslim Funj rulers defeat Christian rulers of Sennar between the Blue and White Nile